

Opinion of the Court

of police. The panel majority identified innocent explanations for most of these circumstances in isolation, but again, this kind of divide-and-conquer approach is improper. A factor viewed in isolation is often more “readily susceptible to an innocent explanation” than one viewed as part of a totality. *Arvizu, supra*, at 274. And here, the totality of the circumstances gave the officers plenty of reasons to doubt the partygoers’ protestations of innocence.

For all of these reasons, we reverse the D. C. Circuit’s holding that the officers lacked probable cause to arrest. Accordingly, the District and its officers are entitled to summary judgment on all of the partygoers’ claims.⁶

IV

Our conclusion that the officers had probable cause to arrest the partygoers is sufficient to resolve this case. But where, as here, the Court of Appeals erred on both the merits of the constitutional claim and the question of qualified immunity, “we have discretion to correct its errors at each step.” *Ashcroft v. al-Kidd*, 563 U.S. 731, 735 (2011); see, e.g., *Plumhoff v. Rickard*, 572 U.S. 765 (2014). We exercise that discretion here because the D. C. Circuit’s analysis, if followed elsewhere, would “undermine the values qualified immunity seeks to promote.” *al-Kidd, supra*, at 735.⁷

A

Under our precedents, officers are entitled to qualified immunity under § 1983 unless (1) they violated a federal statu-

⁶The partygoers do not contest that the presence of probable cause defeats all of their claims.

⁷We continue to stress that lower courts “should think hard, and then think hard again,” before addressing both qualified immunity and the merits of an underlying constitutional claim. *Camreta v. Greene*, 563 U.S. 692, 707 (2011). We addressed the merits of probable cause here, however, because a decision on qualified immunity alone would not have resolved all of the claims in this case.